

Unicorn Project Assignment 3

WEBD-3012 (278692) Business Systems Build and Testing

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RED RIVER COLLEGE Full Stack Web Development

Question 1

How would you describe the state of team morale at the Dockside meeting?

In my opinion, the team “Rebellion” in Chapter 5 shows high employee morale, with a strong and healthy within the team itself. Members are very supportive and willing to help one another. As Kurt mentioned the three agendas on page 83, they share intelligence on who needs help and share things they have learned lately or new technologies that they think could change the game in the Parts Unlimited company. Any frustration present does not come from conflict within the team but from the broader organization. The group is discussing problems created by poor systems and high-level management decisions, not interpersonal issues.

For example, members addressed several issues. On page 77, Dwayne wanted to migrate the database to MySQL instead of the current Kumquat DB. Adam had an issue with a driver, so he tried to generate a driver patch to fix it, but it failed after they launched a new version without reflecting his code. Dave wants to bring back the days when a developer could create value, but the company is now run by executives who do not have any knowledge of technology. They need to get permission from three to four levels of management even when there is a small change. As the company grows, the number of employees has increased on one project, and now too many cooks spoil the broth.

These members really want to contribute to building a world-class tech organization and creating an engineering culture. Kurt addressed these problems to a few of his upper-level managers. One of them agreed, but someone like William is procedural rather than proactive. Although the process is inefficient, William does not take ownership of improving it. Instead, he operates within existing structures and delays meaningful action, even though he is polite and not hostile to Maxine in the earlier chapters.

Also, project funding is driven by visible metrics rather than by long-term value. Therefore, managers feel pressured to make work appear busy to retain the budget. This discourages investment in foundational work such as building an automated way to create environments, perform code builds, or even tests. On page 82, Maxine also shared her concerns and doubts about launching the Phoenix Project with the members. Luckily, they are very supportive and willing to help, and they even added it as a third agenda item to discuss the progress. We can find this through Maxine’s expression on page 83. She is very excited and amazed at what this group has been doing and that she has been chosen to help.

Question 2

How does Parts Unlimited determine its priorities and when a project is ready to go production? Do these priorities align with the developers? Why or Why not?

In Chapters 5 and 6, Parts Unlimited determines its priorities through executive approval, business timelines, and organizational control rather than system wide impact. A project is considered ready to go into production when it receives senior management sign-off and aligns with business or marketing expectations, even if the underlying systems are fragile or incomplete.

This is shown most in Chapter 6, when Sarah sends an email stating that even small production changes must go through her or Chris. This shifts decision-making away from technical teams and toward centralized approval. As a result, priorities are shaped by who has approval authority and what can be escalated, not by engineering judgment.

These priorities do not align with developers like Maxine, who prioritize the entire system, including environment consistency and operational stability. While Maxine and engineers like her think in terms of responsibility, the organization rewards narrowly scoped task completion with approval processes. As a result, developers who care about the whole system are constrained.

In Chapter 6, Wes directly challenges Sarah by pointing out the operational and human limits the organization is ignoring. He explains that despite continuous pressure to fix the Phoenix issues, the teams are already stretched to their limits and there is little more they can realistically do. He says to Sarah “How do we keep our people healthy enough so they can actually do their jobs? And how do we keep them happy enough so they don’t quit?”. Through this statement, the company’s priorities are not aligned with team. His concern is not only system stability, but also the sustainability of the people maintaining those systems. He further explains that multiple engineers have already left or are close to leaving, showing that the current way of pushing projects forward is not sustainable.

This example reveals that projects are being pushed toward production based on business urgency. Even though leadership expects continuous progress, rebooting systems is often the only immediate option, and deeper fixes require time, staffing, and structural changes that are not being prioritized.

Question 3

What are the current devops processes and behaviors that Parts unlimited currently has implemented?

Parts Unlimited currently has several identifiable DevOps processes that are procedural rather than automated. First, production changes are controlled through a centralized approval process. In Chapter 6, Sarah states in an email that all production changes, including small ones, must be approved by her or Chris, showing that deployments depend on managerial sign-off rather than automated pipelines on p.93–94. Second, incident response relies on manual operational procedures. During the Phoenix outage, Wes explains that the main action available to Operations is restarting systems, indicating a defined but manual recovery process instead of automated rollback or self-healing mechanisms on page 95. Third, coordination between Development and Operations occurs through ticket workflows. Developers must submit tickets to access logs or production information, which contributes to troubleshooting delays observed by Maxine during the Phoenix release. These processes describe how development and operations currently function at Parts Unlimited.